Joseph Stalin implemented the ‘Not one step back’ mandate on the 28th of July 1942. This measure was put in place to ensure the army was driven by fear. Those who tried to flee or showed the slightest indication of cowardice were to be executed. Behind the Soviet lines, there were extra soldiers prepared to shoot any withdrawing weaklings or 'traitors to the Motherland.’

Initially, Stalin's spies had cautioned him over and over about the pending German attack but he did not trust them. This is why the Germans face little resistance when they invaded Russia. Operation Barbarossa was initiated at 4 a.m. on the 22nd of June 1941. More than 3 million Axis troops are known to have advanced along the 900-mile front.

On that day, one fourth of the Soviet Union's air power was destroyed. Before the end of October, Moscow was just sixty-five miles away. More than 500,000 square miles of the Soviet region had been captured. A large number of Soviet troops and civilians were murdered and 3 million Red Army fighters were taken as prisoners of war. The international war guidelines for prisoners were violated because the Germans did not care much about rules.

Before the end of June, Finland, Hungary, and Albania had all announced war on the Soviet Union. For Finland, it was a ‘sacred war’ because it was a chance to seek revenge for the Soviet invasion that occurred years ago. During this week, Stalin went through what was known to have been a mental breakdown. He vanished into his room and did not give any orders to his officials for some time. When the Politburo came for him, Stalin dreaded it was to replace him with another leader. However, the committee only asked him what they should do. Stalin addressed his officials on the 3rd of July and gave his famous speech on the ‘The Great Patriotic War’.

At this time, the German forces were beginning to slow down. The further they ventured, the more extended the supply lines became. As Russian forces retreated, they left behind destruction of any resource that could be used by the Germans. Everything including crops, domesticated animals